courtier, would be blindly accepted, no matter the weight of their reputation nor, indeed, the lack of it. Every novel idea and weighty personage was coldly and carefully analysed, as Akbar sought to ‘see’ into the very heart of truth.

Instead of spending his childhood as befitted a Timurid prince, practising calligraphy and learning astronomy, mathematics, history, and philosophy, Akbar spent those years in the company of his beloved animals and their keepers, and his foster family. He raced pigeons, and ran alongside camels and dogs, and hunted cheetahs, lions, tigers, and deer. And, most importantly, Akbar tested his physical strength and courage against wild bull elephants, learning to ride and tame them when they were at the very height of their ferocious ill-temper. In fact, he would test himself almost to the point of insanity, putting himself in harm’s way so consistently and so provocatively that it would appear that only extraordinary luck and a divine will kept him alive.

Akbar was to use this vast physical courage all his life, as he threw himself into battle from the age of twenty, to create an empire that would encompass most of the subcontinent up to the Deccan as well as present-day Afghanistan, Pakistan, and Bangladesh. The only other Indian empire[*] to bring more of the subcontinent under its control was the Mauryan Empire,[†] and its greatest emperor, Ashoka, would be the only ruler in Indian history to be ranked in the same league as the Mughal Padshah by many. Although a detailed comparative study of the two is beyond the scope of this book, the Muslim emperor and the Buddhist emperor who ruled eighteen centuries before him had some traits in common and we will touch upon these briefly later in the book. Because so much of history writing is Eurocentric, the history of Asia and India can sometimes become entirely the story of colonization, of the inevitable spread of European technology and modernity to a region which was seen as backward and somehow lacking in civilizational greatness. What can become obscured is that at the end of the sixteenth century, arguably the greatest empire on earth was the Mughal. That, indeed, the three great empires at the time—the Turkic[*] Ottomans, the Persian Safavids, and the Timurid Mughals (that made up the Dar al-Islam[†])—were Islamicate. Each of these was more magnificent than anything the world had seen before. And, of the three, it was the Mughals, led by Akbar, who would create the greatest wealth. In 1615, as quoted by historian Richard M. Eaton, ‘one observer estimated the Mughals’ annual